

THIS ISSUE TRAINS · CHECKING ASSUMPTIONS BEFORE CONCLUSIONS

Money and markets

The World Bank projects UAE growth of 5 percent in 2026. The Central Bank of the UAE projects 1.7 percent, rebounding to 9.8 percent in 2027. Both employ hundreds of analysts; neither is careless.

The gap lives entirely in their assumptions about oil production, visitor numbers and how the country's other industries perform. A forecast is a calculation with a date on it. The honest way to read one is to hunt down what it assumes before believing what it concludes.

The SCD takeaway: two honest forecasts can disagree wildly because the number is downstream of the assumptions.

Sources: Arabian Business reporting on the World Bank; Gulf News reporting on the Central Bank of the UAE.

Engineering corner

Filming atoms just before they break. Researchers captured the first atomic scale movie of a material in the instants before radiation driven decay, and the footage overturned an assumption: atoms roam and rearrange before the damage strikes. Engineers had mostly inferred the process from the wreckage afterwards; now they can watch it.

The SCD takeaway: a measurement beats an inference. When you can look, look.

Source: ScienceDaily, March 24, 2026.

Your move

Any model, a forecast, a credit score, an app predicting your grade, is only as honest as its inputs. The output looks precise either way, and precision is not accuracy.

This week, on your own: pick an app that shows you a number about yourself, a score, a prediction, a streak. Write down two things it must be assuming and one way to test either.